

Interface-Scoped Dispatch: General Delegation with $O(1)$ Self-Calls

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The conceptual appeal of object composition lies in its ability to build loosely coupled systems from independent runtime components. Yet conventional object composition lacks late-bound self-calls, or *open recursion*, a defining strength of implementation inheritance. Restoring open recursion while retaining the properties of object composition remains an unmet challenge.

We present *Parts*, a general delegation model that unifies independent runtime components, arbitrary composition, and open recursion. Its enabling mechanism, interface-scoped dispatch (ISD), assigns composite identity per interface at construction, allowing self-calls to dynamically dispatch through overriding composites. *Parts* is realized as a compiler plugin for Java 8–27 with IDE integration. It achieves $O(1)$ dispatch cost that is empirically equivalent to a standard vtable call, providing open recursion through composition without sacrificing the independence and flexibility that make object composition attractive.

CCS Concepts: • **Theory of computation** → **Object oriented constructs**; • **Software and its engineering** → **Polymorphism**; **Inheritance**.

Additional Key Words and Phrases: object composition, delegation, open recursion, self-calls, dynamic dispatch, interface-scoped dispatch, mixins, traits, inheritance, Java

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1 Introduction

Object composition is the standard approach to structuring behavior from reusable components [1]. Most object-oriented languages support composition through some form of *forwarding* [16], providing an alternative to implementation inheritance and its well-known hazards, including fragile base classes and coupling to superclass internals. Forwarding, however, gives up a property that makes inheritance particularly useful: *open recursion*. With open recursion, a component’s self-calls remain late-bound, allowing them to reach overrides supplied by a surrounding composition. Without it, self-calls are fixed to the component’s local implementation and cannot reach such overrides. Thus, conventional composition preserves independent components but loses the dynamic self-dispatch that makes inheritance effective for extensible behavior.

The challenge is to recover open recursion without giving up the essential properties of object composition. A model that fully meets this challenge must provide three properties: *independent components*, meaning late-bound objects supplied at construction; *arbitrary composition*, meaning unrestricted composition topologies; and *open recursion*, meaning self-calls that remain late-bound through the composite. Existing composition approaches achieve at most two of these three properties (Section 7).

The composition mechanisms of conventional languages differ in syntax and implementation but reduce to forwarding. Some, such as Rust and Swift, require forwarding to be written explicitly;

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others, including Kotlin's by clause [29] and Go's struct embedding [31], provide it automatically. These mechanisms support independent components under arbitrary composition, but forwarding alone cannot preserve the composite identity required for open recursion: a component's this remains the component itself, so its self-calls cannot be redirected through a composite. This is the *Object Schizophrenia* problem [4, 16].

Trait composition, including Scala's with [11] and mixins [5], makes the opposite trade. Self-calls through this dispatch within the composed hierarchy, so overrides remain visible. But traits and mixins are fused into the hierarchy at compile time and execute as a single runtime object. The constituent components therefore lose independent runtime identity, while composition is statically fixed rather than dynamically defined.

Several research projects (Section 7) have explored *delegation* [3, 15] as a means of retaining independent components while restoring open recursion. These models improve on conventional forwarding, but so far support only restricted composition topologies rather than the arbitrary topologies available through ordinary forwarding (Section 3.3). Many also introduce auxiliary mechanisms to maintain composite identity, which increase implementation complexity and, in some cases, incur substantial runtime overhead.

We present *Parts*, a general delegation model that resolves these long-standing limitations by combining independent runtime components, arbitrary composition, and open recursion. Its enabling mechanism, *interface-scoped dispatch* (ISD), uses *links* to assign composite identity per interface at construction to *parts*, components that participate in delegation. A part's self-calls then dispatch dynamically through the composites that claim the corresponding interfaces. Because identity is assigned per interface rather than per component, different interfaces of the same component may participate in different composites, allowing open recursion under arbitrary composition topologies while preserving independent runtime objects. Links also support non-part components, providing ordinary forwarding when delegation is not required, so delegation and forwarding can coexist within the same composite.

The model's guarantees are established constructively: the dispatch invariant and $O(1)$ self-dispatch cost follow by construction, and the safety rules by static enforcement in the compiler and IDE (Section 4). A mechanized metatheory is a natural complement left to future work (Section 6.4).

The core contributions are:

- **Parts:** a general delegation model in which independent runtime components can be composed arbitrarily, with partial delegation, open-recursive self-dispatch, and statically enforced interface contracts. The model is defined over standard interface hierarchies with a central dispatch invariant (Invariant 1) and composite-scoped encapsulation (@internal).
- **Interface-scoped dispatch (ISD):** the enabling mechanism that assigns composite identity per interface at construction, allowing open recursion under arbitrary composition through partial delegation, where a composite may claim a proper subset of a part's interfaces, with self-calls resolved in $O(1)$ time.
- **An implementation:** an open-source compiler plugin [33] for Java 8–27 that realizes *Parts* with $O(1)$ self-dispatch at vtable speed, together with an IntelliJ IDEA plugin.

2 Overview

Consider a minimal example that shows @part and @link working in a concrete single-rooted composite.

```
interface Actor {
    void takeAction();
    void attack();
}
```

```
99 }
100
101 @part class Hero implements Actor {
102     public void takeAction() { attack(); }
103     public void attack() { println("Swing club!"); }
104 }
105
106 class Wizard implements Actor {
107     @link Actor actor;
108     Wizard(Actor actor) { this.actor = actor; }
109     public void attack() { println("Cast spell!"); }
110 }
111
112 new Wizard(new Hero()).takeAction(); // "Cast spell!"
```

When Wizard is constructed, the compiler wires Hero's composite identity for Actor to Wizard. A call to takeAction() dispatches to Hero.takeAction(), and the self-call attack() within it dispatches back through Wizard, invoking Wizard.attack(), not Hero.attack().

This is the decorator pattern with one addition: the wrapped object's self-call routes back through the composite. A plain decorator would forward takeAction() to the Hero, where the attack() call would stay on Hero ("Swing club!"), losing the override.

Because the link field accepts any Actor at construction time, the part is a real late-bound object, not fused into the class hierarchy. A different Actor implementation can be substituted without changing Wizard.

Interface contracts are enforced at compile time. The link field has type Actor, and the compiler verifies that Wizard implements the delegated interface. A raw part may not escape the composite dispatch path: passing or assigning this as the concrete part type is a compile error; interface or Object types are required (Section 4.5).

This example is single-rooted where Wizard is the sole composite for Hero, and one composite identity suffices. The next section shows where a single composite identity breaks down, and how assigning identity per interface fixes it.

3 The Model

3.1 Motivating example

The following example shows a part with interfaces rooted at different composites. Hero implements both Combatant and Actor, and two wrappers decorate it. A Wizard changes how it fights (Combatant), while a Demon partially possesses it, seizing its name and will (Actor) but leaving its trained combat untouched. As in the overview, the wrapped hero's self-calls route back through the wrappers; now two wrappers claim different interfaces of the same part. So from a single Hero instance, attack() must dispatch to Wizard and name() to Demon. A single composite identity cannot serve both. Assigning a separate composite identity per interface resolves this. Figures 1 and 2 show the structure.

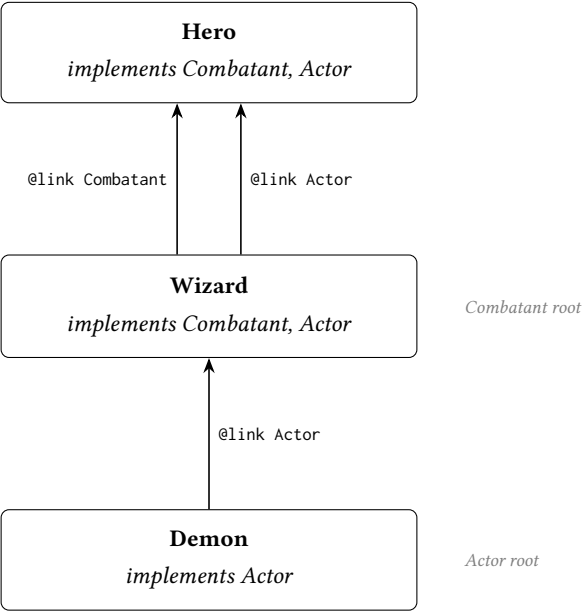


Fig. 1. Composition structure. Arrows show link fields labeled by the delegated interface. Wizard is the root for Combatant dispatch; Demon is the root for Actor dispatch.

```
197 interface Combatant {
198     void attack();
199 }
200 interface Actor {
201     String name();
202     void takeAction();
203 }
204
205 @part class Hero implements Combatant, Actor {
206     public void attack() { println("Swing club!"); }
207     public String name() { return "Milo"; }
208     public void takeAction() {
209         print(name() + " acts: "); // Actor dispatch
210         attack();                 // Combatant dispatch
211     }
212 }
213
214 @part class Wizard implements Combatant, Actor {
215     @link Combatant combatant;
216     @link Actor actor;
217     Wizard(Hero h) { this.combatant = h; this.actor = h; }
218     public void attack() { println("Cast spell!"); }
219 }
220
221 class Demon implements Actor {
222     @link Actor actor;
223     Demon(Actor a) { this.actor = a; }
224     public String name() { return "Diablo"; }
225 }
226
227 Wizard wizard = new Wizard(new Hero());
228 Demon demon = new Demon(wizard);
229 demon.takeAction();
230 // Actor dispatch rooted at Demon
231 // Combatant dispatch rooted at Wizard
232 // prints: Diablo acts: Cast spell!
```

Fig. 2. Composition with multiple composite roots per part. Hero carries distinct composite identities for Combatant (rooted at Wizard) and Actor (rooted at Demon).

3.2 Definitions

Parts is defined over a standard typed object model where classes implement interfaces and method dispatch is defined by the receiver's runtime type.

claim an interface of a part is claimed when a composite links that interface, making the composite its exclusive identity within the part.

component a class nominally implementing one or more interfaces, available for delegation if the class is a part and for forwarding otherwise.

composite a class containing one or more links. A composite nominally implements the interfaces declared on its links.

delegation surface a component's interface hierarchy, excluding any interface marked `@internal` in its `implements` clause.

interface an abstract type that defines a contract (a Java interface).

link an ordinary field annotated with `@link` and typed as an interface. The enclosing class (the composite) delegates the link's declared interface to the component assigned to the link at construction. Links are implicitly `private` and `final`; explicit modifiers are redundant.

part a component annotated with `@part`, enabling compiler plugin support for open recursion.

partial delegation a requirement for arbitrary compositions, where a composite may claim only some of a part's delegation surface.

root (of an interface) the linking composite claiming an interface of a part.

When a composite links an interface to a part, the part is directly wired to the composite. It records a *composite identity*: a reference to the composite statically indexed by the interface. The part's self-calls route through the composite indexed by the interface of the called method. The enabling mechanism is *interface-scoped dispatch* (ISD).

A part may itself contain link fields, in which case composite identity propagates transitively. When such a part is wired to an outer composite, that composite becomes the dispatch root for each interface it claims throughout the delegation chain, while interfaces it does not claim retain the roots established by inner composites. This *transitive propagation* continues through a link field only when the field's value is a part and the field's declared interface and the claimed interface are comparable, one a subtype of the other (Figure 6).

Composites must also resolve *diamonds*. When a composite has multiple links that share a common interface, a sharing link must be chosen explicitly via `@link(share=I.class)` at one of the link sites. This determines the leg of the diamond the linking composite forwards through for its implementation of the interface. Diamonds consisting of multiple shared interfaces require the same `share=I.class` to select the sharing links for each interface, where a single link can share multiple interfaces or the interfaces can be shared separately from any of the other links capable of sharing them. Wiring is unaffected: self-calls on common interfaces from other legs of the diamond naturally route through the shared leg.

Two practical extensions, composite-scoped encapsulation (`@internal`) and abstract parts with deferred linkage (`asLink()`), are defined and implemented (Section 4).

Dispatch rule. Traditional object-oriented dispatch resolves a call through the receiver's object identity:

$$\text{call } m() \text{ on } o \longrightarrow \text{vtable}(o, m)$$

Interface-scoped dispatch replaces the single object identity with a per-interface composite identity. A self-call $m()$ in part P where $m \in I$ resolves through the composite identity for I :

$$\text{self-call } m() \in I \text{ in } P \longrightarrow \$\text{selfes}_P[I].m()$$

For self-calls within a part's methods, the dispatch triple is (*part*, *interface*, *method*) rather than the conventional (*object*, *method*). Figure 3 contrasts this per-interface routing with a single shared composite identity. This is *open recursion*: a method's self-calls late-bind to the most-derived receiver. Here the receiver resolves from the interface of the self-call. Forwarding is the closed case: a component's self-calls stay in the component, and the composite never enters the recursion.

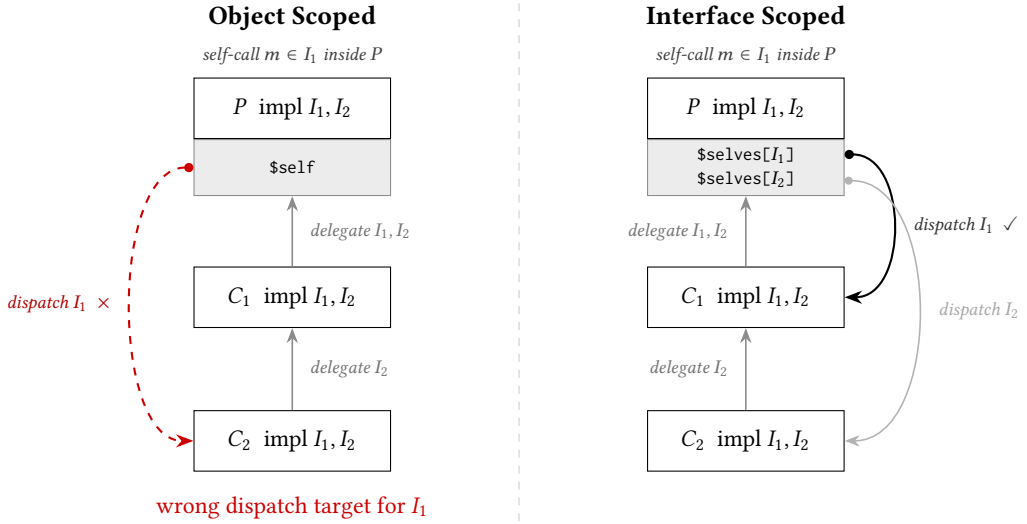


Fig. 3. Object-scoped vs. interface-scoped dispatch. In both panels C_2 (impl I_1, I_2) delegates only I_2 to C_1 (impl I_1, I_2), which delegates both interfaces to part P . *Left*: a self-call $m() \in I_1$ inside P routes through $\$self = C_2$, the wrong composite for I_1 . *Right*: $\$selves[I_1]$ routes to C_1 ; $\$selves[I_2]$ routes to C_2 ; each self-call reaches its correct composite root.

INVARIANT 1. For any part P in a delegation chain for interface I rooted at composite C : a self-call this.m() within P where $m \in I$ dispatches to C .

Composite identity is single-valued per interface. A part's $\$selves$ slot for I holds exactly one composite, established at construction, with the most recent wiring of I determining it. The root C in the invariant denotes this current occupant and is therefore always well-defined. Whether a given wiring order matches the programmer's intent is, as with any construction-time assignment, the programmer's responsibility.

The invariant is established by construction. When composite C establishes a link to part P for interface I , the plugin-generated $\$linkPartToSelf$ (Figure 6) sets $\$selves_P[I] \leftarrow C$ and recurses into P 's own links, propagating C 's identity for each interface C claims and leaving all other slots unchanged. Each interface of a part resolves through a single $\$selves$ slot. Wiring an outer composite that claims I re-roots this slot to that composite and leaves the slots for interfaces it does not claim unchanged, so the slot holds exactly one root at any time and stabilizes once the outermost composite claiming I is wired; C denotes that final root. Each write occurs during the wiring composite's construction. Wiring happens solely as link field assignment, and the plugin enforces final on link fields, so writes are confined to construction: the $\$selves$ slots are never written after the outermost composite claiming I is constructed.

Visibility follows from safe publication. Once the composite root is safely published, the Java Memory Model guarantees that any thread observing it sees all writes that happened-before publication, the wired slots included. The role of final here is write-confinement, not the JMM's final-field freeze. Since array-element writes are not covered by freeze semantics, the guarantee rests on write-confinement together with safe publication of the root, not on the finality of the slots.

Self-calls in P where $m \in I$ are rewritten by the plugin to $((I) \$selves[IDX_I]).m()$. For self-calls through the delegation surface, there is no code path in a part method that dispatches

through anything other than the indexed slot. Because the slot holds C once the composition is constructed and is not written thereafter, the invariant holds at every point a self-call can execute. Before wiring, each slot is initialized to `this`; an unwired part dispatches on itself, consistent with standard object-oriented dispatch. In this initial state, the invariant holds trivially. A full mechanized proof in a Featherweight Java subset is a natural direction for follow-on work (Section 6.4).

3.3 Arbitrary Composition

Mirroring the structural flexibility of standard object composition and forwarding, Parts supports unrestricted topologies. These are expressed as behaviorally acyclic graphs where nodes are parts, composites, or ordinary objects, and edges are link fields. Each edge establishes a connection from a composite to a component through the interface specified by the link.

Partial delegation permits a composite to claim only the interfaces it needs from a part's delegation surface, leaving the remaining interfaces for other composites to claim. This freedom gives rise to the four composition topology primitives shown in Figure 4 and classified over two dimensions: the number of roots a part maintains and the number of sources the composition has. A root is an outermost node claiming one or more interfaces of a part's delegation surface; a source is a node with no incoming link edges.

- (a) **Single-root, single-source.** Composite A implements I_1, I_2 and delegates both to B , which implements both directly. A 's links claim all of B 's delegation surface, so B has one root, A , for both interfaces, and one source. This is the topology typical of decorator chains.
- (b) **Multi-root, single-source.** Composite A implements I_1, I_2 and delegates only I_1 to B , which implements I_1, I_2 directly. Because A does not claim B 's I_2 , I_1 is rooted in A , while I_2 is rooted in B : one source, two roots. A and B in turn may delegate their free interfaces to separate components that participate in another subgraph that likewise decomposes into one of these four topologies. The motivating example discussed previously (Figure 1) is an instance of this topology combined with (a) where B delegates both its I_1 and I_2 to another part, propagating A and B as the part's roots for I_1 and I_2 .
- (c) **Multi-root, multi-source.** Component C implements I_1 and I_2 , where A claims I_1 and B claims I_2 . As in (b), C has different roots for its two interfaces, but here A and B are independent sources. This echoes subject-oriented programming's independent *subjects*, composed with no single subject designated as owner (Section 7). Figure 5 exercises this directly.
- (d) **Cyclic, multi-root, sourceless.** Composite A implements I_1, I_2 and delegates I_1 to B , which implements I_1, I_2 and delegates I_2 back to A . Such structural cycles are permitted when delegation through them is behaviorally acyclic because each traversal proceeds through a distinct interface: I_1 is rooted in A , and I_2 is rooted in B . Cycles over nondistinct interfaces are rejected (Section 4).

Each of the four topologies illustrated takes its reduced form using as few nodes and edges as possible while retaining the essential properties that make the topology distinct. Topologies (a) and (b) each have a single source, but (b) is multi-root; (c) is multi-root and multi-source; (d) is multi-root and sourceless. Topology (d) is structurally cyclic but behaviorally acyclic over distinct interfaces.

These four are exhaustive over the two dimensions. Of the six combinations the dimensions admit, two cannot occur: a single-rooted part forces a single source, and a sourceless graph is necessarily multi-root. This leaves (a)–(d).

Forwarding admits these topologies, so by definition a general delegation model must as well. The topologies therefore provide a basis for verifying whether a delegation model supports arbitrary

composition: does its treatment of open recursion remain correct under arbitrary extensions of each topology?

To answer this question, another set of labeled edges may be drawn onto the structural delegation graph to form a second graph in which each part is connected to the composites claiming its interfaces, determined by following the delegation edges backwards along each interface of the part's delegation surface to the outermost composite claiming the interface. This derived identity graph reveals what open recursion under arbitrary composition requires: composite identity assigned per interface.

In all four cases, for each delegated interface, a part acquires the identity of the composite claiming that interface, independent of where execution enters the composition. Invariant 1 holds independently for each interface.

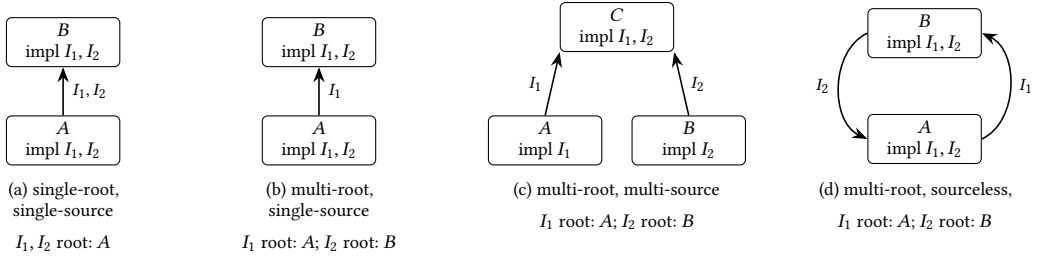


Fig. 4. The four primary composition topologies under partial delegation. Arrows point from a delegating composite to the part it links. (a) and (b) have a single source; (c) has two sources; (d) is sourceless.

```

442 interface Actor { void takeAction(); int timeLimit(); }
443 interface Combatant { int strengthLevel(); }
444
445 @part class BasicHero implements Actor, Combatant {
446     private int elapsedTime = 11;
447     public void takeAction() { println("Attack with strength: " + strengthLevel()); }
448     public int timeLimit() { return 10; }
449     public int strengthLevel() { return outOfTime() ? 0 : 8; }
450     private boolean outOfTime() { return elapsedTime > timeLimit(); }
451 }
452 class PaidSubscriber implements Actor {
453     @link Actor actor;
454     PaidSubscriber(Actor actor) { this.actor = actor; }
455     public int timeLimit() { return 100; }
456 }
457 class SuperSoldierAddon implements Combatant {
458     @link Combatant combatant;
459     SuperSoldierAddon(Combatant combatant) { this.combatant = combatant; }
460     public int strengthLevel() { return combatant.strengthLevel() * 10; }
461 }
462 BasicHero basicHero = new BasicHero();
463 PaidSubscriber subscriber = new PaidSubscriber(basicHero);
464 SuperSoldierAddon addon = new SuperSoldierAddon(basicHero);
465 subscriber.takeAction(); // reaches SuperSoldierAddon's strengthLevel()
466 // PaidSubscriber and SuperSoldierAddon hold no reference to each other.
467 // prints: Attack with strength: 80

```

Fig. 5. Topology (c): two independent composites, PaidSubscriber and SuperSoldierAddon, claim different interfaces of the same BasicHero with no common composite. The call subscriber.takeAction() reaches self-calls through the respective roots: strengthLevel() through SuperSoldierAddon and timeLimit() through PaidSubscriber.

4 Implementation

The implementation is a javac plugin that operates directly on the compiler's AST before and after two phases: *Enter* (symbol definition) and *Analyze* (semantic processing).

For the Enter phase, the plugin generates structural scaffolding. Here, @part classes are processed to add the \$selves identity array, the \$linkPartToSelf wiring method, and if the class is abstract, the \$Impl subclass and asLink() factory methods. Composite classes are also processed here to add forwarding methods corresponding with @link delegation. At Analyze, @part classes are processed to rewrite self-calls and to enforce self-preservation rules (Section 4.5). @link field assignment is also rewritten here to invoke wiring, and to enforce @internal.

4.1 Part Transformation

Each part holds a \$selves array with one slot for each interface on its delegation surface. The ordering of the array's slots is compile-time-determined according to the part's class information.

```

486 private final Object[] $selves = {this, ..., this};
487 // after wiring: $selves[IDX_I] = composite identity for interface I

```

Array slots are initialized with this, so a part's self-calls dispatch on itself by default.

Within a part, every call `this.m(args)` where `m` is declared in interface `I` is rewritten to:

```
((I) $selves[IDX_I]).m(args)
```

The cast ensures interface method invocation via the `invokeinterface` instruction, allowing the call to dispatch through the composite's implementation of that interface.

The ordinal `IDX_I` is assigned per part over its own delegation surface, so it is local to that class: the rewritten self-calls and the generated `$linkPartToSelf` both reside in the part and share its indexing, and no index agreement across separately-compiled classes is required.

```
public void $linkPartToSelf(Object root, Class<?>[] linkScope) {
    // cycle detection
    if (this == root) Internal.reportCycle(this, root);
    // wire the part's 'linkScope' interfaces to 'root'
    outer:
    for(Class<?> linkIface : linkScope) {
        for(int i = 0; i < $INTERFACE_CLOSURE.length; ++i) {
            Class<?> iface = $INTERFACE_CLOSURE[i];
            if (iface == linkIface) {
                this.$selves[i] = root;
                continue outer;
            }
        }
        throw new DelegationLinkageError("Unimplemented linked interface: " + linkIface);
    }
    // recursively call $linkPartToSelf to rewire the part's related links to 'root'
    Class[] scopeLinkField1 = Internal.widest($LINK_FIELD_1, linkScope);
    if (scopeLinkField1.length != 0 && this.linkField1 instanceof $PartClass) {
        (($PartClass)this.linkField1).$linkPartToSelf(root, scopeLinkField1);
    }
    // likewise for the linkField2, etc.
}
```

Fig. 6. Generated `$linkPartToSelf` for a part class. `Internal.widest` returns the wider of two narrowest-first ordered interface arrays, or an empty array if the arrays are not comparable.

4.2 Composite Transformation

A composite nominally implements every interface claimed by its links. For each method of a claimed interface that the composite does not implement directly, the plugin generates a delegating method that forwards through the corresponding link field:

```
R m(args) { return link.m(args); }
```

Each link field assignment `this.link = part` is transformed to invoke `part.$linkPartToSelf(this, I.class)`, wiring the part's `$selves` slot for the link's declared interface `I` to the composite. If the part itself links that interface to another part, the generated method recursively rewires that linked part to the same composite (Figure 6).

4.3 Abstract Part Support

A part may be abstract, deferring some interface methods to the composite. Linking an abstract part obligates the composite to implement those methods or to be declared abstract. When enforceable at compile time, the plugin generates a delegating method for each interface method implemented by the part, but none for methods it leaves abstract. Without those methods, a concrete composite is flagged by the compiler to either implement them directly or declare itself abstract. This is the compositional analog of the rule that a concrete class must implement its inherited abstract methods.

To make an abstract part instantiable for linking, the compiler generates a private `$Impl` inner subclass with stubs that throw `DelegationLinkageError`, and an `asLink()` factory per constructor:

```
private static final class $Impl extends AbstractClass {
    $Impl(/* AbstractClass ctor params */) { super(...); }
    @Override public R m(/* params */) {
        throw new DelegationLinkageError("Abstract method called");
    }
}
public static Foo asLink(/* ctor params */) { return new $Impl(...); }
```

Once wired, the stubs are unreachable for a statically configured abstract part. Self-calls dispatch through `$selves` to the composite, where the compile-time obligation guarantees an override. The stubs enforce the runtime configured case when the linking composite does not override any of the part's abstract methods. The stubs also serve as a runtime guard for direct abstract method calls on an `asLink()` instance.

4.4 Default Methods

If left unmitigated, a default method runs with the part as receiver, rather than the composite, when neither the composite nor the part overrides it, resulting in incorrect self-call dispatch.

A default method cannot be directly invoked with a receiver other than the current `this`. The implementation uses a method handle bound to an invokedynamic call site to work around this limitation. When a part does not override a default, the plugin generates an override that invokes the interface's default implementation in this way, with the receiver taken from the `$selves` slot of the interface that *provides* the default implementation, which may differ from the interface that declares the method. The default body then runs with a `this` that implements the default's interface, so its self-calls dispatch through the composite claiming that interface, as a self-call on that interface would.

```
interface Foo {
    void bar();
    default void foo(P p) { bar(); } // self-call
}
@part class FooPart implements Foo {
    public void bar() { ... }
    // generated
    // calls Foo.super.foo() with composite in $selves as receiver
    public void foo(P p) {
        invokedynamic Foo::foo((Foo) $selves[IDX_Foo], p);
    }
}
```

The site's bootstrap links it once to a fixed target (the default implementation), with the receiver as its only varying argument. Being monomorphic, it is inlined by the JIT to the same type of $O(1)$ array-indexed invocation as in Section 5.

4.5 Safety Guarantees

Cycle detection. If a part is wired to itself, directly or transitively, over the same interface, `DelegationLinkageError` is thrown at assignment time during the recursive `$linkPartToSelf()` call (Figure 6).

@internal enforcement. `@internal` may annotate an interface method or an interface type literal in a class's `implements` clause, with distinct effects. A method annotated with `@internal` is accessible only within the composite, the same intent behind `protected` in implementation inheritance, but more cleanly scoped for composition. A type literal in a class's `implements` clause annotated with `@internal` removes that interface from the class's delegation surface: no composite may claim it via a link field.

Self-preservation. Inside a part, the compiler restricts both implicit and explicit uses of `this` that could expose the part's concrete identity outside the composite dispatch path. Field access, private calls, and callbacks through the part's own link fields (the compositional analog of `super`) are permitted. Passing or assigning `this` as the concrete part type is rejected because a caller holding the bare part could invoke methods outside the composite dispatch path and violate Invariant 1. Interface-typed and Object-typed uses remain permitted: the former resolve through ISD to the composite claiming the interface, while the latter resolve to the part's own object identity.

A bare self-call is ambiguous when the method belongs to multiple interfaces, including when unrelated interfaces inherit it from a common interface. The self-call's `this` receiver must be qualified via casting to the intended interface (Figure 7). In this way parts can target separate unrelated overrides of the same method. This behavior is vital for multi-source structures of topology (c) (§3.3), common with subject-oriented designs.

```

638 interface A { String a(); String z(); }
639 interface B { String b(); String z(); }
640 @part class AB implements A, B {
641     public String a() { return ((B)this).z() + " " + ((A)this).z(); }
642     public String b() { return ((A)this).z() + " " + ((B)this).z(); }
643     public String z() { return "AB.z"; }
644 }
645 class AImpl implements A {
646     @link A a;
647     AImpl(A a) { this.a = a; }
648     public String z() { return "AImpl.z"; }
649 }
650 class BImpl implements B {
651     @link B b;
652     BImpl(B b) { this.b = b; }
653     public String z() { return "BImpl.z"; }
654 }
655 AB ab = new AB();
656 AImpl a = new AImpl( ab );
657 BImpl b = new BImpl( ab );
658 println(a.a()); // "BImpl.z AImpl.z"
659 println(b.b()); // "AImpl.z BImpl.z"

```

Fig. 7. Self-calls to overlapping method `z()` in interfaces `A` and `B` must be cast-qualified to the intended interface. Here, part `AB` reaches both implementations of `z()` by selecting the target interface with casting.

5 Evaluation

5.1 Dispatch Performance

The dispatch path for a self-call through a composite is:

- (1) Load `$selves[IDX_I]`, an array-indexed load with compile-time constant index
- (2) Cast to `I`
- (3) `invokeinterface m`, standard JVM virtual dispatch

This is $O(1)$. The parallel to `vtable` dispatch is direct. A `vtable` call is an indexed slot load followed by an indirect call. A self-call within a part is therefore on equal footing with a `vtable` call.

Benchmark. We verify this empirically using JMH [32] in average-time mode. Each scenario calls `compute()` through a composite root at chain depth d (1–6). The *baseline* traverses d `@link` delegation hops to a leaf that returns directly, with no self-call. The *concrete* variant traverses the same hops but the leaf issues a self-call (`$selves[IDX_I].scale()`) from a concrete part method, dispatching through the composite root. The *default* variant issues the same self-call from an inherited interface default method the leaf does not override, routed through the generated `invokedynamic` override of Section 4.4. The delta (concrete minus baseline) isolates the cost of the self-call dispatch mechanism alone. All runs: 10 JVM forks, 5 warmup iterations, 10 measurement iterations per fork (100 data points per cell); errors are $\pm$ half-width of the 99.9% confidence interval. A separate single-dispatch calibration run (`invokeinterface` on a monomorphic call site, same harness) yields 0.43 ns/op; the delta values in Table 1 are therefore roughly 1–2 $\times$ a single virtual dispatch.

Choice of baseline. The delta is measured against Parts's own forwarding path, which establishes the baseline: that path is semantically equivalent to Kotlin by and Lombok @Delegate (Section 7), so the delta prices exactly the self-call routing those mechanisms cannot express, against their own dispatch cost. A cross-system benchmark against other composition models would price differences in implementation strategy rather than the self-call dispatch this delta isolates, so that comparison is analytic (Section 7).

Table 1. Self-call dispatch cost by delegation depth (JMH, average-time mode; ns/op, $\pm 99.9\%$ CI half-width). *Baseline* traverses the delegation hops with no self-call. *Concrete* and *Default* add one self-call through the composite, issued from a concrete part method and from an inherited interface default (via `invokedynamic`) respectively. The delta (Concrete minus Baseline) isolates the self-call dispatch cost over plain delegation. Values are rounded from the measured means and intervals. The delta combines the Baseline and Concrete cells (difference of means, half-widths in quadrature) and may differ from the rounded column difference by 0.01 ns.

Depth	Baseline (ns)	Concrete (ns)	Default (ns)	Delta (ns)
1	0.62 $\pm$ 0.02	1.16 $\pm$ 0.03	1.18 $\pm$ 0.03	0.55 $\pm$ 0.03
2	0.91 $\pm$ 0.03	1.56 $\pm$ 0.04	1.55 $\pm$ 0.04	0.65 $\pm$ 0.05
3	1.18 $\pm$ 0.03	1.93 $\pm$ 0.05	1.92 $\pm$ 0.05	0.75 $\pm$ 0.06
4	1.64 $\pm$ 0.03	2.30 $\pm$ 0.06	2.23 $\pm$ 0.06	0.66 $\pm$ 0.07
5	1.93 $\pm$ 0.06	2.70 $\pm$ 0.06	2.76 $\pm$ 0.07	0.77 $\pm$ 0.09
6	2.37 $\pm$ 0.06	3.21 $\pm$ 0.09	3.23 $\pm$ 0.08	0.84 $\pm$ 0.11

Across depths 1–6 the delta remains bounded, on the order of a single virtual dispatch (the 0.43 ns calibration above), consistent with one array-indexed load (`$selves[IDX_I]`) followed by `invokeinterface`. The self-call routes through a dynamically wired `$selves` slot, so its receiver is not statically known and the dispatch does not fold away: the delta is one virtual dispatch, with the array indexing on top (confirmed free below). The $O(1)$ claim is structural: one dispatch per self-call, independent of depth, with the per-call cost pinned by the isolation measurement below. The small upward drift in the delta across depths (0.55 to 0.84 ns) stays well under a second dispatch and plausibly reflects less complete inlining of the dispatch site within the larger compiled method at greater depth. The *default* column tracks the *concrete* column within $\pm 3\%$ at every depth, with the sign of the difference varying. The two are indistinguishable at this resolution. The interface-default template, dispatched through `invokedynamic`, carries no measurable cost over the concrete part template, confirming the equivalence claimed in Section 4.4. The comparison is steady-state: the one-time bootstrap that links each `invokedynamic` site is absorbed during warmup and is not measured here.

Isolating the array index. The depth-series delta is essentially one virtual dispatch. To confirm the `$selves` array indexing adds nothing on top, we isolate the dispatch. Holding a target method non-inlinable so a real call occurs, we compare three depth-0 forms over the same receiver: a `vtable` call (`invokevirtual`), the `invokeinterface` it compiles to, and the plugin's emitted form (`((I) $selves[IDX_I]).m()` (an `Object[]` element load, a cast, and `invokeinterface`). Over 10 JVM forks (JDK 21) the three are statistically indistinguishable. The ISD form differs from the bare `invokeinterface` it emits by 0.03 ± 0.09 ns, and from `invokevirtual` by 0.10 ± 0.05 ns, both within the fork-to-fork variance of the measurement. The array-element load is not separately observable, therefore the self-call costs one virtual dispatch and no more. This is the empirical content of the `vtable`-equivalence claim.

Construction cost. The result above is the steady-state call cost; wiring is paid once, at construction. Building a composite invokes `part.linkPartToSelf` (Figure 6) at each link assignment involving a part, which sets the part's relevant `$selves` slots and recurses through the part's own link fields, propagating composite identity for each interface the composite claims, where the interface is comparable to the link field's interface. Each pass does constant work per part per claimed interface (an identity check for cycle detection, a constant-time scope comparison, and no allocation). Wrapping an already-linked composite re-propagates its subtree, so total wiring cost grows with delegation depth, which is small in practice. None of this lies on the dispatch path, so the per-call cost is unchanged.

5.2 Example: Teaching Assistant

The following example exercises diamond dispatch resolution and self-call routing through the composite. A teaching assistant (TA) is both a student and a teacher where both roles share a common `Person` base.

```
interface Person {
    String name();
    String title();
    String titledName();
}

interface Student extends Person { ... }
interface Teacher extends Person { ... }
interface TA extends Student, Teacher { ... }

@part abstract class PersonPart implements Person {
    private final String name;
    public PersonPart(String name) { this.name = name; }
    public String name() { return name; }
    public String titledName() { return title() + " " + name(); }
}

@part class StudentPart implements Student {
    @link Person person;
    public StudentPart(Person p) { this.person = p; }
    public String title() { return "Student"; }
}

@part class TeacherPart implements Teacher {
    @link Person person;
    public TeacherPart(Person p) { this.person = p; }
    public String title() { return "Teacher"; }
}

@part class TaPart implements TA {
    @link(share=Person.class) Student student;
    @link Teacher teacher;
    public TaPart(Student student) {
        this.student = student;
        this.teacher = new TeacherPart(student);
    }
    public String title() { return "TA"; }
}
```

```
}  
  
TA ta = new TaPart(new StudentPart(PersonPart.asLink("Milton")));  
ta.titledName(); // "TA Milton"
```

With forwarding, the shared `Person` methods must each be resolved by hand, and `titledName()` still calls `title()` on the delegate's own `this`. `Parts` resolves both problems.

`PersonPart` holds the template once. Its self-call to `title()` dispatches through the composite at each level of the delegation chain.

`titledName()` is defined once in `PersonPart` and not overridden. Diamond resolution is handled statically: `@link(share=Person.class)` designates `student` as the forwarding link for `Person`, `TaPart` transitively claims `Person` throughout the composite.

6 Discussion

6.1 Partial delegation and part identity

Partial delegation is a requirement for arbitrary composition, where a composite may claim only some of a part's delegation surface. *Multi-rooted parts* result from this condition: a part's interfaces may be rooted at two or more distinct identities, including the part itself and one or more composites, via any combination of the multi-rooted topologies in Section 3.3.

The possession example in Section 3 demonstrates an extended version of topology (b): `Demon` claims only `Actor` from `Wizard`. Through delegation propagation, `Hero` consequently has separate roots for `Actor` and `Combatant`, making it a multi-rooted part through a single source graph, `Demon`. The `PaidSubscriber/SuperSoldierAddon` example (Figure 5) demonstrates topology (c): multiple roots within a multi-source composition.

This multi-rootedness makes a part's identity context-sensitive. References to this, whether implicit or explicit, resolve according to the interface through which they are used. When that interface is claimed, ISD resolves this to the claiming composite. Otherwise, this remains the part itself. This is a direct resolution of the Object Schizophrenia problem mentioned in Section 1.

6.2 Language Design Implications

`Parts` addresses several longstanding limitations of implementation inheritance:

- **Fragile base class** [2]: a composite's dependency surface is the interface contracts it explicitly claims, not a component's internal implementation; changes to its encapsulated internals do not propagate. Partial delegation completes the isolation: a composite is unaffected by changes to interfaces it does not claim.
- **Forced IS-A semantics**: reuse does not require a type relationship; the composite is a subtype of the interface, not of the component's implementation.
- **Hierarchy-bound**: implementation inheritance binds behavior to a class hierarchy and a single object identity, making independently rooted compositions of the same component impossible. `Parts` permits arbitrary topologies by assigning composite identity per interface.
- **The Object Schizophrenia problem** [4]: a hazard with forwarding where self-calls remain within the component rather than routing through the composite; resolved by ISD.
- **Diamond ambiguity**: `Parts` provides explicit `@link(share=I.class)` resolution; ambiguous diamonds left unresolved are compile errors rather than being silently merged.
- **Unintended interface exposure**: a composite may implement a subset of its parts' interfaces; those it does not implement are absent from its API by construction. `@internal`

strengthens this further: a class may declare selected interfaces as internal to its implementation and excluded from its delegation surface, preventing the interfaces from being claimed by a composite.

- **Abstract behavior:** abstract parts with deferred linkage (`asLink()`) preserve the template-method capability of abstract classes without coupling their implementation and hierarchy.

Implementation inheritance’s power is open recursion. Its fragility is the surface that power ranges over—every accessible member. Parts retains open recursion but bounds the surface to the declared interface contract. Self-calls still reach the composite’s overrides, while the internals that make base classes fragile are never exposed.

Implementation inheritance and Parts are, essentially, two bindings of the same open recursion: implementation inheritance binds it to the class hierarchy, where a subclass IS-A its superclass and inherits its entire implementation surface, while Parts binds it to a held object and its delegation surface, where the composite HAS-A its parts and IS-A only its interfaces. The concept that inheritance and open recursion are separable is Cook’s [6, 7], and the modeling of inheritance as composition is Bracha and Cook’s [5]. Cook’s model threads self as an explicit parameter; Parts wires composite identity per-interface at construction.

6.3 Concurrency

A constructed composition is safe to share across threads. Each interface’s `$selves` slot may be written during construction as links are established; the last write determines the resulting root. Once construction is complete, the slots are never written again, so the JMM makes the final wired state visible to any thread observing the safely published root. No synchronization is required on the dispatch path. The guarantee is scoped to a single composition and relies on the single-value identity per interface established in Section 3. Parts may hold mutable state under standard Java rules and dispatch adds no synchronization points.

6.4 Future Work

Per-interface composite roots as a general primitive. Assigning dispatch identity per interface at construction is, perhaps, a primitive that may be applied in areas beyond this paper’s focus. It is an unexplored subject whether problems currently addressed through dynamic dispatch, AOP weaving, or collapsed component hierarchies could benefit from the same mechanism.

Formal verification. A mechanized proof of Invariant 1 using small-step operational semantics would provide rigorous structural verification beyond the constructive proof sketch outlined in Section 3. Because the Parts model maps cleanly onto a core calculus, a modified subset of Featherweight Java serves as a natural starting point for formalizing these type-safety and execution guarantees.

Link timing and mutability. Through final links, composite identity is finalized at construction. This read-only guarantee is what makes sharing lock-free (Section 6): stable wiring needs no synchronization on the dispatch path. Two relaxations of the rule, opt-in *lazy* and *mutable* links, are worth exploring, and they go in opposite directions.

A *lazy* link changes only the timing. Backed by the stable-value facility of recent JDK releases (Project Leyden), it wires on first use instead of at construction, yet stays written once and effectively final, so the guarantee holds while link initialization is deferred. A *mutable* link lifts the restriction. Mutating link assignments become legal, restoring the only aspect of conventional forwarding Parts disallows (runtime reconfiguration) but sacrifices the guarantee and under the same thread-safety obligations as a regular mutable field. Both relax restrictions of the current model rather than

changing the underlying composition model. Whether a mutable link can also keep the guarantee, by confining rewiring to safe-publication points, is an open question.

Domain modeling and persistence integration. Normalized relational schemas naturally represent domain types as independently owned sets of data and relationships, whereas object-relational mapping often pressures those types into inheritance hierarchies. Table-per-hierarchy collapses types into a single hierarchy, often producing sparse, null-heavy tables; table-per-subclass preserves a more normalized representation but retains the coupling of inheritance. Conventional composition avoids that coupling but gives up open recursion. Parts is positioned to remove this tradeoff: independently modeled types can remain separate components, composed according to the domain's relationships while retaining open recursion across the composition. This suggests a domain model in which the object structure can mirror the normalized schema directly rather than introducing an inheritance hierarchy solely to retain open recursion. How such a mapping could be realized as a persistence framework is an open question.

7 Related Work

While Parts assumes static typing, this section also considers dynamically typed models where the structural comparisons remain conceptually instructive. The discussion is organized around the three properties that characterize Parts: independent runtime components, arbitrary composition, and open recursion.

Forwarding and conventional composition. Kotlin's by keyword [29], Lombok's @Delegate [30], Scala 3's export [28], and Go's struct embedding [31] provide forwarding from a composite to a supplied component. These mechanisms preserve independent runtime objects and permit the component structure to be composed freely. Self-calls, however, remain in the component's scope rather than dispatching through the composite. They therefore provide the first two properties but not open recursion.

Mixins and traits. Bracha and Cook [5] formalized mixins as parameterized abstract subclasses, while Schärli et al. [8] introduced traits as stateless, composable units of behavior. Odersky and Zenger [11] later introduced statically typed mixin composition with abstract type members. Scala's with clause linearizes traits into the target class at compile time, so self-calls dispatch through the outermost class in the resulting hierarchy. These systems therefore provide open recursion, but composition occurs by fusing the contributed behavior into a single class or object rather than by supplying an independent component at construction. A component implementation cannot consequently be selected or replaced independently at construction, nor can a single component instance participate independently in multiple composites. This fusion is also characteristic of recent precisely-typed mixin systems [12]. Parts separates the two: open recursion is provided by interface-scoped dispatch without fusing the component into the composite.

Chugh's ISOLATE [13] gives a statically typed calculus for functional objects in which *premethods* are defined apart from a host object and later mixed into it. ISOLATE provides typed open recursion without an explicit fixpoint, but the resulting object is still assembled by mixin composition rather than from an independently supplied runtime component. It therefore occupies the same side of the tradeoff: open recursion without independent runtime components.

Family polymorphism and dynamic composition. Family-oriented systems such as gbeta [20, 22], CaesarJ [23], Object Teams/Java [24], and J& [21] support extensible families whose members can participate in open recursive composition. Their object structure, however, is defined by the family model: members are instantiated as part of the family rather than supplied as independent runtime components.

Newspeak [25] makes names late-bound and permits classes to be supplied as first-class constructor arguments, supporting runtime wiring and reconfiguration of module objects. Its open recursion derives from mixin inheritance [5]: classes are applied to superclasses and fused into a single object. Composed module objects are instead held by reference and reached through ordinary message sends, so self-calls do not route through the composition. Newspeak therefore combines dynamic composition with open recursive inheritance, but does not provide open recursion across independently composed runtime objects in the Parts sense.

Delegation. Several research systems have explored delegation as a way to retain independent runtime objects while restoring open recursion.

Kniesel’s DARWIN [15, 16] provides statically typed delegation-based single implementation inheritance. A base object is supplied at run time through a delegatee field, and self-calls route through the inheriting subtype. DARWIN permits at most one delegating or forwarding field per class [16, §6.5]; multiple delegation is deliberately excluded [16, §6.5.1]. A receiver typed through a single interface therefore cannot represent multiple independently rooted compositions [16, §5.5.4]. DARWIN provides independent components and open recursion, but is effectively limited to the single-root, single-source topology (a).

Incomplete Featherweight Java (IFJ) [18] similarly provides static typing, independent runtime objects, and open recursion through *incomplete objects* completed by other objects at run time. Its delegation is structural and per method, however, with a single `this` binding for the delegation chain. A component therefore cannot root different interfaces at different composites. Its composition is consequently confined to topology (a) (§3.3). Parts instead associates each interface with a specific composite through `@link`, permitting the multi-rooted and multi-source topologies induced by partial delegation.

DelphJ [17] is a Java-based research language that augments its MorphJ metaprogramming DSL with delegation features (*access-paths*) as a means for open recursion. Its runtime-supplied *subobjects* generally support late-bound self-calls, but the access-path mechanism is designed around a single-rooted delegation structure, which incurs substantial runtime costs from constructing and merging access paths for stack-held references and traversing them on self-calls. Crucially, the access-path strategy does not provide the per-interface identity required by arbitrary composition. In particular, the model cannot correctly resolve cross-interface self-calls to methods common to separately claimed interfaces, as required by topologies (b),(d) (Figure 7). Additionally, access paths cannot support cross-interface self-calls at all with topology (c) (§3.3). Its composition is therefore limited to topology (a). Parts inverts the access-path strategy: composite identity is fixed in the component rather than reconstructed by the caller on every access. This single design choice is what makes delegation under arbitrary composition possible.

Delegation at larger granularity. Ostermann’s delegation layers [19] extend delegation from individual objects to entire collaborations composed at run time. Operations are routed to the composed collaboration rather than to a single layer, providing “composition consistency.” The unit of composition is a collaboration, however, whose participants are nested classes redirected through the enclosing instance. The model therefore provides open recursion at collaboration granularity rather than through independently supplied components, and does not provide the per-component partial delegation that gives rise to multi-rooted and multi-source topologies.

Prototype-based delegation provides another form of open recursion. Lieberman [3] introduced *open delegation*, in which an object delegates unanswered messages to a prototype while self remains the original receiver; Self [9] realized this model in a working language. These systems support late-bound components and open recursion, but delegation is object-granular rather than interface-scoped. A prototype supplies all behavior not handled by the delegating object, so partial

delegation and the resulting multi-rooted topologies are not expressible. Their dynamic typing also provides no static interface contract for the composed result. Cecil [10] explores a statically typed point in this space, separating subtyping from code inheritance, but does not provide dynamic inheritance of the kind relevant here.

Subject-oriented programming [26, 27] is particularly relevant to multi-source composition. It composes independent *subjects*, each representing a complete view of a shared domain, using externally specified composition rules such as merge and override. The model explicitly targets decentralized composition in which no subject is the sole owner of the result. This corresponds closely to the multi-source structure of topology (c). The original model and its implementations, however, do not preserve independently composed runtime objects in the final representation and do not provide static typing across the composed result [27]. Parts addresses the same structural problem at the granularity of an individual runtime object, using interface-scoped identity under a statically checked interface contract.

Multiple inheritance. C++ virtual base classes and virtual inheritance [14] resolve inheritance diamonds within a single object and its merged class hierarchy. They therefore address ambiguity among inherited implementations rather than composition among independently supplied runtime components. Multiple inheritance does not provide the independent component identity or dynamic composition considered by Parts.

Novelty. The surveyed systems divide naturally according to the three properties of Parts. Forwarding provides independent runtime components and arbitrary composition, but not open recursion. Mixins, traits, family systems, and related forms of class composition provide open recursion, but fuse the components into a statically determined object structure. Delegation systems such as DARWIN, IFJ, and DelphJ restore open recursion while retaining independent runtime components, but restrict the composition topologies they can represent.

The closest prior systems are therefore the delegation models. DARWIN deliberately excludes multiple delegation [16, §6.5.1]; IFJ binds a single *this* across its delegation structure; and DelphJ's access-path mechanism, the most capable of the three, still limits composition to only the simplest single-rooted case. None provides all three properties together: independent runtime components, arbitrary composition, and open recursion.

Parts unifies the three properties through interface-scoped dispatch. By assigning composite identity per interface at construction, ISD allows a single component to participate in the arbitrary compositions of forwarding while preserving late-bound self-calls. The resulting self-dispatch path has $O(1)$ cost and is empirically equivalent to a standard vtable call.

8 Conclusion

The advice to favor object composition over class inheritance came with an unspoken cost: composition gives up the open recursion that made inheritance practical. Parts removes that cost. By assigning composite identity per interface at construction, it shows that open recursion need not be tied to inheritance's single runtime object; the two can be separated without compromise. The result is a general model that retains the essential properties of simple forwarding—*independent runtime components and arbitrary composition topologies*—while adding open recursion at vtable speed.

Data-Availability Statement

Two artifacts support this paper: the `javac` compiler plugin implementing the Parts model, and an IntelliJ IDEA plugin providing IDE integration for it. Both are complete and will be submitted for

Artifact Evaluation. Links are withheld from this submission for double-blind review and will be made available upon publication.

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